

Field work safety discussion

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two general principles

- Safety is the most important thing.
No scientific data are worth someone getting hurt!
- Safety is everyone's responsibility.
Don't wait for someone else to take care of safety issues, even if you are not 'in charge'.
When you are in charge, be alert to others, listen to them, and be willing to adjust.

potential safety issues

- (1) staying hydrated (*don't forget electrolytes, either*); heatstroke
- (2) sunburn
- (3) hypothermia
- (4) falls, cuts, sprained ankles, etc.; injuries from machinery (including noise)
- (5) injuries related to low visibility to hunters &/or to drivers
- (6) venomous, stinging, or otherwise dangerous animals; allergenic or stinging plants; animal-borne disease

more potential safety issues

- (7) getting lost
- (8) driving when tired
Leave the field site before you are exhausted; take breaks on long drives; etc.
- (9) other driving issues: driving carefully; "turn around, don't drown"; flat tires, etc.
- (10) wildfire
- (11) floods
Even if the day is dry and sunny, it may have rained upstream.
- (12) tornados, hurricanes, storms, lightning

Plan ahead - examples

- first, identify safety issues
- daily schedules, including driving, meals, and breaks
- maps, directions
Don't count on cell phone contact everywhere.
- first aid kits
- appropriate protective gear for everyone & extras
- someone to check in with when you leave and return, who can serve as a contact in an emergency
- vehicle maintenance, spare tire, etc.
- self-evacuation plans for wildfire, floods, etc.

problematic interactions with other people

general principle:

- Look out for each other! Speak up!

(13) problems involving people on your field work team

Examples: from unequal work loads, through disregarding safety issues, to Title IX issues

(14) problems involving people not in the field work team

Examples: differential treatment of team members by the Border Patrol; casual prejudice in stores; assuming the white male is in charge; misunderstandings due to language or cultural differences; interactions with criminals

Plan ahead for these, too!